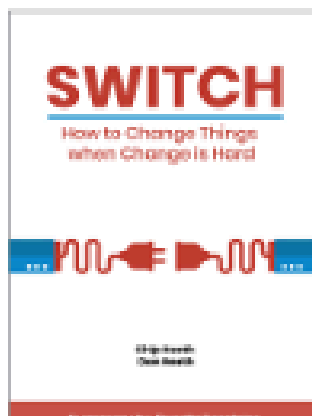




SWITCH

How to Change Things when Change is Hard

Chip Heath & Dan Heath

The Big "So What"

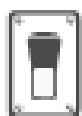
Making lasting change in our companies, communities and our own can be hard, because of inherent conflict in our minds. **This book shows us a 3-part framework that can help us to achieve desired change-at individual, organizational and societal levels-with significant results.**

3 Surprises about Change

Change is like trying to get an elephant (with all its inertia) to travel down a new path. **To succeed, there are 3 ingredients-the "Rider", the "Elephant" and the "Path"**-which must be addressed. These are built on 3 insights about change.

1. What looks like resistance is often a lack of clarity.

Often, people don't change not because they resist it, but they are unsure how to change. For example, "eat healthy" is vague but "go for the 1%-fat milk instead of whole milk" is specific.



To get people to change,
give crystal-clear direction.

2. What looks like laziness is often exhaustion.

Our minds are ruled by 2 different and often-conflicting systems-the rational mind (our reflective or conscious system that deliberates, analyzes and plans ahead) and the emotional mind (our instinctive part that feels pain and pleasure).

KEY QUOTES

"This is a book to help you change things. We consider change at every level – individual, organizational, and societal."

"The basic three-part framework we...unpack in this book...can guide you in any situation where you need to change behaviour."

When the 2 systems are in conflict, the emotional mind tends to take over, and it takes a lot of self-control for the rational mind to stay in charge. **Self-control or willpower is an exhaustible resource.** Each time we try to change things, we are going against what is automatic for us, and this takes willpower. When our self-control is exhausted, we give up.



To change things, appeal to both the rational and emotional minds.

3. What looks like a people problem is often a situation problem.

How do we get people to eat less? Often, we assume that the amount of food people consume has to do with their lifestyle, habits, knowledge about food etc. Yet, according to a study in 2000, people with bigger containers simply ate more food, which means, the key to helping people to eat less can be as simple as giving them smaller containers.



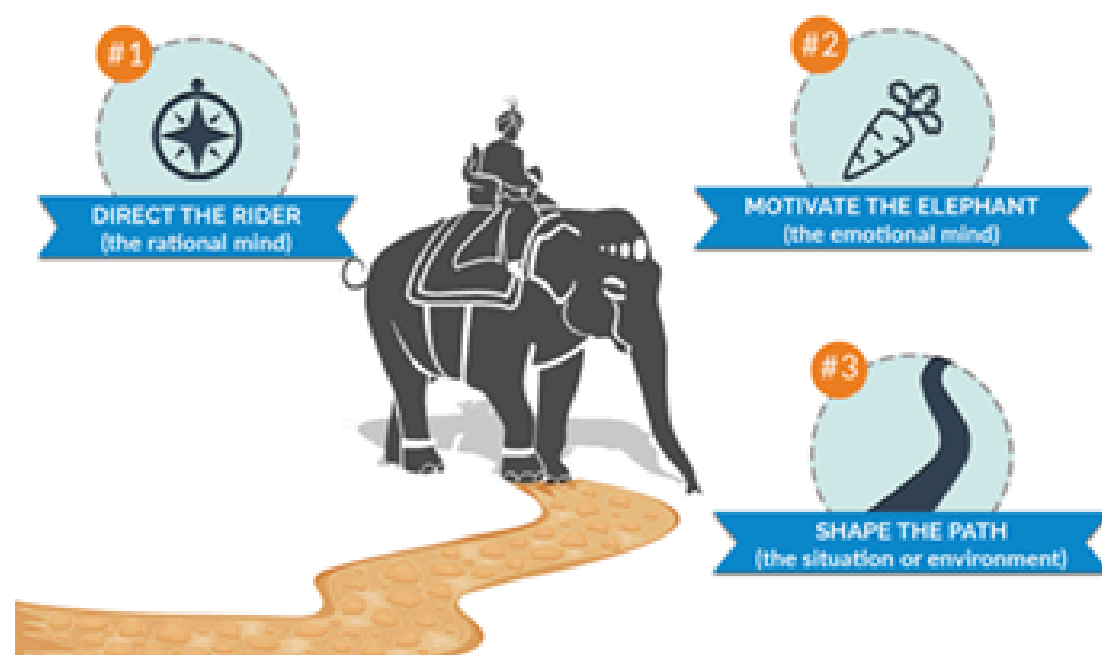
To change someone's behaviour, change that person's situation.

The Rider and the Elephant

Throughout the book, the Heath brothers use the analogy of the "Rider" and "Elephant", by psychologist Jonathan Haidt. The Rider represents our rational side trying to control the massive Elephant which represents our emotional side. The Rider may appear to be in control, but whenever the Rider and Elephant cannot agree on where to go, the Rider eventually loses.

KEY QUOTES

The key to change is to address all 3 elements: The Rider, The Elephant and the Path.



Direct the Rider



The Rider part of our mind has great strengths and an important role to play—it's a thinker, planner, and helps us to chart the path for the future. However, its key weakness is its tendency to over-analyze problems. Hence, **the best way for change to take place is to direct the rider. Show him (not just tell him) exactly where to go and what needs to be done.**

Find the Bright Spots



Big problems often come with numerous and seemingly overwhelming challenges. Rather than analyze all of them, the best place to start is to **look for and focus on exceptions to the problem**, i.e. for the first hint of possible miracles. These bright spots can give us an action plan. In short, **find the bright spots, analyze them to define the solutions, then clone them.**

In tackling the rampant malnourishment issue in Vietnam in the 1990s, Jerry Sternin zoomed in on "bright spot mothers" who managed to raise healthy kids despite the challenging conditions. He looked for small deviations in what they did, and discovered that these mother achieved results through simple cooking and feeding habits that could be emulated by any of the locals. By organizing small community cooking groups where families could come together to practice the solutions, he tackled the Rider, Elephant and Path at the same time.

KEY QUOTES

"The Rider's capacity for analysis is endless. Even success can look like problems to an overactive Rider."

"To make progress on a change, you need ways to direct the Rider. Show him where to go, how to act, what destination to pursue."

"These flashes of success – these bright spots – can illuminate the road map for action and spark the hope that change is possible."

Society generally has a "bad is stronger than good" bias. Of the 24 most common "emotion" words in English, only 6 of them are positive. The newspapers are also full of sensational bad news. **To motivate change, we need to shift our Rider from a problem-focus to a solution-focus.** Using bright spots help us to do so because they show what's possible.

Script the Critical Moves



When we have more choices and options, we tend to feel overloaded, leading to decision-paralysis. Because change brings new choices, it creates uncertainty and indecision. **When faced with decision-paralysis, people stick to the status quo by default.**

Hence, in circumstances of change, it is not enough for leaders to set high-level direction. They need to translate ambiguous goals and a broad change idea into concrete and specific behaviors i.e. to script the critical moves.

Point to the Destination



In creating change, it helps to **give people a "destination postcard" which shows a vivid picture of what is possible in the near future.** This gives a clear idea of where we are heading, taps into feelings that inspire us, and shifts the Rider's focus from over-analysis to answering the question "how do I get to the destination?".

An effective destination postcard should:

1. Be both specific and worthwhile
2. Be aligned with the short-term critical moves

Motivate the Elephant



Find the Feeling



Often, we assume that people resist change because they don't understand the need for it, hence we instinctively try to teach them or share more information.

Change is not about understanding,
but about feeling.

KEY QUOTES

"More options, even good ones, can freeze us and make us retreat to the default plan...This behaviour is not rational, but it is human."

"Big-picture, hands-off leadership isn't likely to work in a change situation, because the hardest part of change – the paralyzing part – is precisely in the details."

"In creating change...we're interested in goals that are closer at hand...We want a goal that can be tackled in months or years, not decades."

"Trying to fight inertia and indifference with analytical arguments is like tossing a fire extinguisher to someone who's drowning. The solution doesn't match the problem."

 **See-Feel-Change.** When it comes to changes, the correct sequence is See-Feel-Change, not Analyze-Think-Change (Kotter & Cohen). Changes bring uncertainty; with so many new variables and new information, people won't think themselves into change. **Rather, people change when they see things that cause them to feel for the outcomes that the changes can bring.**

 **The fallacy of self-evaluation.** Even if we are presented with all the facts, **our evaluation of the situation or ourselves will be inaccurate because our self-evaluation is emotionally biased.** We tend to be overly optimistic about where we are at and how we are doing, and these positive illusions hinder our ability to orientate clearly.

 **Negative vs positive feelings.** Negative feelings (e.g. anger, fear, dismay) can be used to motivate quick and specific action. People will usually make a leap when they feel that their circumstances are so dire they have no choice but to do so. However, such negative feelings tend to have a "narrowing effect" on our thoughts. On the other hand, **the positive emotion of interest can bring about a different type of change, built on creativity, inspiration and flexibility.**

Shrink the Change



 **Don't start at the starting line.** People are more motivated to be involved in a longer journey that's partially finished, than a shorter journey that's just starting. **Motivate action by helping people to feel that they are already on the way to the finish line.**

For example, if you want customers to buy 8 additional car washes to get a reward, give them a 10-slot card with 2 "bonus" stamps. This will be more effective than giving them an empty 8-slot card. Make an effort to **remind people what's already been achieved, rather than focus solely on what's new and different about the upcoming changes.**

 **Engineer early success.** Break down a daunting task into small parts that are so easy that people can't help but score a victory, i.e. create small wins at an individual level. Once people start on the path, **make their progress (however small) visible.** This gives people hope, and demystifies the journey.

KEY QUOTES

"Change is not one of understanding but one of feeling."

"One reason we're able to believe that we're better-than-average leaders and drivers and spouses and team players is that we're defining those terms in ways that flatter us."

"When we are interested, we want to get involved, to learn new things, to tackle new experiences. We become more open to new ideas."

"To motivate action...make people feel as though they're already closer to the finish line than they might have thought."

With each successful step, people will feel the change more, and the change seems progressively smaller compared to their own growth.

Grow Your People



People with fixed mindsets believe that their abilities and potential are fixed based on who they are. People with growth mindsets believe that abilities can be built up with practice, much like muscles, and there's no limit to what they can learn.

Successful change requires people to have a growth mindset. They understand that "failures" are the best way to learn, and they remain flexible and adaptable in face of changing circumstances and new information. **During times of change, it is important to constantly remind people that our abilities can be strengthened with practice.**

Shape the Path



Most of us are prone to the "fundamental attribution error", i.e. we tend to blame the person and discount the environment. For example, if a driver were to cut into our path, we are more likely to conclude that he/she is a rude or reckless driver, than to consider if he/she is facing an unusual emergency.

How we behave is systematically shaped by the environment or situations we are in. To get people to change, we can provide clear direction, provide motivation and determination, or simply give an easier path or a simpler journey to make.

Tweak the environment



To minimise an undesired outcome (e.g. injury from drunk driving), you can use pre-event intervention (e.g. penalties against drunk driving), event intervention (e.g. seat belts and air bags), and/or post-event interventions (e.g. emergency medical teams).

However, **the most effective way to eliminate undesired behaviour is to make that behaviour impossible**, e.g. removing unhealthy snacks from the house altogether, or shifting the furniture in a room to change how people interact. **Small tweaks in the environment can make a huge difference in shaping behaviours.**

KEY QUOTES

"When you engineer early success, what you're really doing is engineering hope. Hope is precious to a change effort. It's Elephant fuel."

"Small targets lead to small victories, and small victories can often trigger a positive spiral of behaviour."

"Failing is often the best way to learn, and because of that, early failure is a kind of necessary investment."

"You know you've got a smart solution when everyone hates it and it still works – and in fact works so well that people's hate turns to enthusiasm."

"Simple tweaks to the Path can lead to dramatic changes in behaviour."

Build habits



Habits are our behavioural autopilots. When we are acting according to our habitual practices, we don't need to exercise or "waste" any willpower. **Forming the right habits make our actions seem effortless.**

Action triggers are useful for forming new habits quickly e.g. "I will go to the gym after I send Ann to school". By imagining a time and place when we will do something, it has the effect of "preloading" a decision, so we are effectively forming an "instant habit". There's no need to consciously exercise willpower to recommit to our decision or motivate ourselves to do what we should.

Habits that support changes should:

1. Advance the mission
2. Be easy to embrace

Ask yourself: "How can I set up a situation that brings out the good or desired behaviours in these people?" **Use checklists to show people what/how to do things, and to avoid blind spots and overconfidence.**

Rally the herd



When people feel unsure about what to do, they look to others for cues about how to behave. Hence, groups tend to respond more poorly than individuals, and we tend to subconsciously imitate others' behaviors.

For successful social change, **create "free spaces", i.e. small-scale meetings where reformers can gather freely away from the pressures of the dominant groups.** This allows them to explore/learn freely, develop a new identity, and prepare themselves for future collective action.

Keep the Switch Going



Change is a process that takes place over time. **The secret to successful change is to reinforce each step of the process.** It is easier to spot problems than progress, hence noticing and reinforcing progress takes effort.

KEY QUOTES

"When you're leading an Elephant on an unfamiliar path, chances are it's going to follow the herd."

"Change isn't an event; it's a process...To lead a process requires persistence."

"When change happens, it tends to follow a pattern. We've got to stop ignoring that pattern and start embracing it."

Other Useful Details in the Book to Look Out For



The Heath brothers help to bring their points to life with numerous examples of past research and studies, real-life stories and illustrations, including health and personal change, business turnaround and sales initiatives, government and conservation efforts, social change and family relationships etc.

The book includes sections called "Clinics", to help us think about how to apply the Switch framework, using real-world situations and suggestions on possible game plans. The Heath brothers also list 12 common problems to change and suggest how to tackle them.

About the Authors of Switch



Chip Heath is a professor at Stanford Graduate School of Business, focusing on courses about business strategy and organizations.

He has consulted with clients such as Google, Gap and The Nature Conservancy.

Dan Heath is a Senior Fellow at Duke University's CASE center, which supports social entrepreneurs. He previously worked as a researcher and case writer for Harvard Business School. In 1997, Dan co-founded an innovative publishing company called Thinkwell, which continues to produce a radically reinvented line of college textbooks. Dan has an MBA from Harvard Business School and a BA from the Plan II Honors Program from the University of Texas at Austin.



Besides this book, the Heath brothers have also co-authored *Made to Stick: Why Some ideas Survive and Others Die* and *Decisive: How to Make Better Decisions in Life and Work*. Their books have been translated into 28 languages todate.

For more details, including free resources, you can go to their official website at <http://heathbrothers.com/>.

KEY QUOTES